

XINCHEN MA

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EDUCATION

London School of Economics and Political Science

Ph.D. in Finance

2020 - 2026 (Expected)

Renmin University of China

M.Phil. in Finance

2017 - 2020

B.Sc. in Finance

2013 - 2017

B.Sc. in Mathematics and Applied Mathematics

2013 - 2017

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Corporate Finance, Data Economy, Financial Technology, Banking

JOB MARKET PAPER

Open Banking and Competition in Banks and Fintech: Evidence from Mobile Apps

Abstract: Open banking policies have been introduced by many governments to foster innovation in financial services, yet evidence on their effects on competition remains limited. I construct a novel dataset of fintech app source code and exploit cross-country variation in open banking availability within the same app to identify the impact of open banking on fintechs. I find that open banking significantly boosts fintech app usage and performance, with the strongest gains for lending and investment apps, fintech startups, and during the pandemic when access to traditional banking was limited. Textual analysis of app descriptions shows that incumbent banks most exposed to open banking suffer declines in loan issuance and income but respond strategically by raising fee intensity and asset yields. Overall, the results underscore the value of data in competition dynamics.

- **Presentations:** EFA 2026 (scheduled), FIRS 2026, AFA 2026 PhD Poster, Trans-Atlantic Doctoral Conference 2025, HEC Paris Finance PhD Workshop 2025, Warwick PhD Workshop on FinTech 2025, LSE PhD Workshop

WORKING PAPER

The Supply and Demand for Data Privacy: Evidence from Mobile Apps

(with Bo Bian and Huan Tang)

Reject & Resubmit at *Journal of Political Economy*

Abstract: We study Apple's privacy "nutrition" label policy, which mandates standardized disclosure of mobile apps' data collection practices. Using Android versions as a control, we find that iOS apps experience a 14% drop in weekly downloads and a 15% drop in revenue in the U.S., with stronger effects for more privacy-invasive apps. Extending the analysis globally, we document systematic heterogeneity in consumer responses explained by institutional and cultural factors. A complementary experiment shows that standardized labels improve comprehension and align stated and revealed preferences, addressing the "privacy paradox". Our findings highlight information transparency as a key barrier to data privacy protection.

- **Best Paper Award** at Annual Conference in Digital Economics 2022
- **Selected Presentations:** SITE 2024, FIRS 2024, EFA 2023, AEA 2023, SFS Cavalcade North America 2023, Colorado Finance Summit 2022, CEPR Household Finance Seminar

WORK IN PROGRESS

Data-Driven Partnerships Among Firms: Evidence from GDPR

Abstract: This paper studies the formation and capital-market implications of data-driven partnerships between firms. I assemble a news-based dataset of inter-firm, data-driven collaborations to map the landscape of the corporate data-sharing network. I document the determinants of partnership formation, partner-pair characteristics, and associated stock-market reactions. Exploiting the EU's General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) as a plausibly exogenous shock in a difference-in-differences design, I show that GDPR-exposed firms form more data-driven partnerships, with the increase concentrated in US deals with non-EU partners, underscoring the privacy-data trade-off for EU firms.

– **Presentation:** LSE PhD Workshop

The Effect of App Tracking Transparency: An Analysis on App Monetization

Abstract: This paper studies how privacy regulation alters app developers' monetization strategies. Exploiting Apple's App Tracking Transparency (ATT) policy, which shifted data-sharing defaults from opt-in to opt-out, I document a 28% decline in downloads and a 10% drop in revenue among tracking apps. Advertising activities contract: publishers display fewer video, banner, and playable ads, while advertisers reduce spending on social platforms. In response, tracking apps adopt more third-party SDKs for advertising and monetization, increasingly substituting toward privacy-compliant attribution tools. Over time, these adjustments lead to higher in-app purchase prices, highlighting the trade-off between privacy protection and platform-based monetization.

Stablecoins on the Move: Mobile App Usage and Macro Stability *(with Jiahong Shi)*

Public data on crypto and stablecoin app usage provides real-time signals of economic conditions.

PRESENTATIONS

- 2026: EFA 2026 (scheduled), FIRS 2026, AFA 2026 PhD Poster Session
- 2025: Trans-Atlantic Doctoral Conference, Warwick PhD Workshop on Financial Technology, HEC Paris Finance PhD Workshop, LSE PhD Workshop
- 2024: FIRS 2024, SIOE 2024, LSE PhD Workshop
- 2023: EFA 2023, 3rd Sustainable Finance Conference, Digital Economy Workshop Lausanne, 19th CEPR-JIE School on Applied Industrial Organization, Compass Lexecon
- 2022: UK Digital Economics Workshop

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

LSE Class Teacher (Undergraduate Courses)

FM300/310 Corporate Finance, Investments and Financial Markets	2023 - 2024
FM212 Principles of Finance	2021 - 2023
FM250 Finance (Summer School)	2023
FM255 Financial Markets and Portfolio Management (Summer School)	2021

LSE Teaching Assistant (Graduate Courses)

EE951 Corporate Finance and Strategy (Executive Program)	2023 - 2025
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RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant to Prof. Huan Tang, London School of Economics	2021
Research Assistant to Prof. Shiyang Huang, University of Hong Kong	2018 - 2019

AWARDS & GRANTS

PhD Studentship, LSE	2020 - 2026
European Finance Association PhD Travel Grant	2025
LSE Class Teacher Award (×3)	2022, 2023, 2024
Nomination for LSE Students' Union Outstanding Teaching Award	2023
LSE Phelan US Centre PhD Summer Research Grant	2023
Best Paper Award, Annual Conference in Digital Economics	2022
First Prize of Undergraduate Thesis Award, RUC	2017
National First Prize of China Undergraduate Mathematical Contest in Modeling	2015
Women's Volleyball Team Tournament Champion, RUC	2015
Academic Excellence Scholarship, RUC	2014

SKILLS

Languages	Chinese (Native), English (Proficient)
Programming	Python, Stata, SAS, MATLAB, SQL, Mathematica, $\text{\LaTeX}$
Techniques	Textual Analysis, Web Scraping, Machine Learning
Certification	Passed CFA Level II
Others	Piano, Volleyball (Setter)

REFERENCES

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